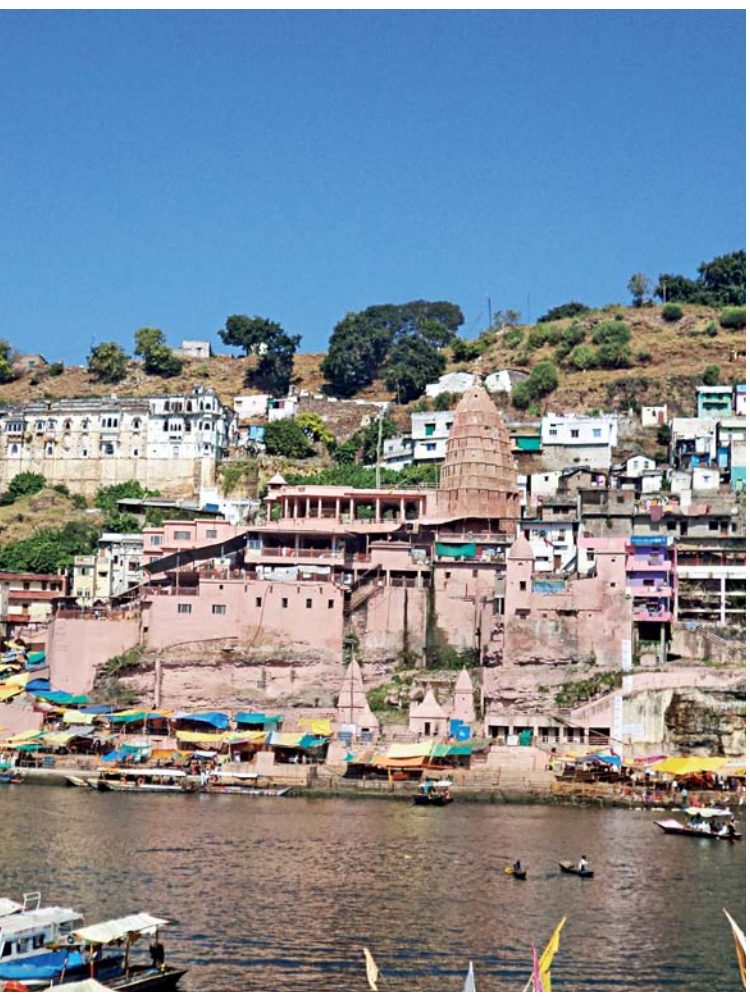
## OMKARESHWAR TEMPLE, KHANDWA, MADHYA PRADESH

When Brahma and Shiva once began to debate who amongst them was supreme, Shiva, it is said, settled the dispute by making himself manifest as a *jyotirlinga* (pillar of light) that had no beginning and no end. At all the 12 sites that he had penetrated, temples were built to remind devotees of his eternal and primordial form. Located in Madhya Pradesh's Khandwa district, Omkareshwar is one such shrine.

Believed to have been built in 1063 by the king Udayaditya, Omkareshwar is said to have been given a facelift in 1195 when Raja Bharat Singh Chauhan saw that a palace was constructed next door. The 60 brown stone pillars in the temple are all 14-ft high, each elaborately carved. Many smaller shrines in the five-storeyed complex—dedicated to Gauri, Annapurna, etc.—offer great views of the Narmada.

**WHAT ELSE TO DO**

Situated in the Satpura Range, 69 km from Khandwa, the Asirgarh Fort is a perfect example of how several architectural styles—Persian, Turkish, et al—can blend to become truly Indian.



SHUTTERSTOCK



SHUTTERSTOCK

## KODANDARAMA TEMPLE, VONTIMITTA, ANDHRA PRADESH

Even though this grand temple was built during the 16th century reign of the Cholas, the credit for its construction goes to thieves, not kings. Legend has it that two burglars, Vontudu and Mittudu, were suddenly so overcome by their devotion for Lord Rama that they decided to build a temple for him. Seeing the grandeur and magnificence of the deity's form, they are said to have turned into stone themselves.

**WHAT ELSE TO DO**

Located 25 km from the temple, the city of Kadapa is home to several churches—St Mary's Cathedral, in particular, stands out—and the much-revered Ameen Peer or 'Pedda' Dargah.

The Vijayanagara architectural style is reflected in the temple's three *gopurams*, the 32 pillars of its *mandapam* and also its *garbha griha* (sanctum sanctorum). The figures of Rama, Sita and Lakshman you see here have all been carved from a single piece of rock. Unlike other Rama temples, one doesn't find Hanuman bent at the feet of his Lord. The monkey-god has been given his own shrine.